

Define Islamic Political System and differentiate between Islamic and Conventional (Secular) Political Systems

Answer:

Definition of Islamic Political System

The Islamic Political System (النظام السياسي الإسلامي) is a divinely guided system of governance based on the sovereignty of Allah (حاكمية الله), implemented through human leadership (Imāmah/Khilāfah), aimed at protecting religion and managing worldly affairs according to the Qur'an and Sunnah to establish justice, welfare, and moral order.

It integrates religion and politics and seeks to realize the objectives of Sharī'ah (Maqāṣid al-Sharī'ah).

Opinions of Different Islamic Scholars

1. Imam Al-Māwardī (d. 450 AH)

In Al-Aḥkām al-Sulṭāniyyah, he defined Imāmah as:

“الإمامة موضوعة لخلافة النبوة في حراسة الدين وسياسة الدنيا”

“Imāmah is established to succeed Prophethood in protecting religion and managing worldly affairs.”

According to him, the political authority is necessary to:

Preserve religion

Implement law

Establish justice

Protect the state

2. Ibn Taymiyyah (d. 728 AH)

In Al-Siyāsah al-Shar'iyyah, he states:

“ولاية أمر الناس من أعظم واجبات الدين”

“Authority over the affairs of people is among the greatest obligations of religion.”

He emphasized:

Justice as the foundation of rule

Governance must serve public interest (maṣlaḥah)

Political authority is essential to implement Shari‘ah

3. Imam Al-Ghazālī (d. 505 AH)

He said:

“الدين والسلطان توأمان”

“Religion and authority are twin brothers.”

He explained:

Religion is the foundation

Political authority protects religion

Without governance, religion cannot function socially.

4. Shah Waliullah Dehlawi

He viewed Khilāfah as:

A system to establish divine guidance

A mechanism to ensure justice and collective welfare

Difference Between Islamic and Conventional (Secular) Political Systems

The Islamic political system is based on divine revelation (Qur’an and Sunnah), while the conventional political system (modern secular system) is based primarily on human reasoning, popular sovereignty, and man-made laws. Below is a structured comparison:

1. Source of Sovereignty

Islamic Political System

Sovereignty belongs to Allah alone.

Law must conform to the Qur’an and Sunnah.

Human authority is limited and accountable.

Evidence:

“Legislation is not but for Allah.” (Yusuf 12:40)

Conventional Political System

Sovereignty belongs to the people (popular sovereignty) or the state.

Laws are made by parliament, congress, or rulers.

No binding divine framework.

2. Source of Law

Islamic System

Based on:

Qur'an

Sunnah

Ijmā' (consensus)

Qiyās (analogy)

Legislation must not contradict Sharī'ah.

Conventional System

Based on:

Constitution

Human legislation

Social contract theory

Majority vote

Laws may change according to social trends.

3. Relationship Between Religion and State

Islamic System

Religion and politics are integrated.

Governance is considered part of religious duty.

Moral accountability in this world and Hereafter.

Conventional System

Often follows secularism.

Religion is separated from politics.

Governance is viewed as a worldly affair only.

4. Objective of the State

Islamic System

Establish justice ('Adl).

Protect religion, life, intellect, lineage, and property (Maqāṣid al-Sharī'ah).

Promote moral and spiritual development.

Conventional System

Maintain order.

Protect rights and freedoms.

Promote economic and political stability.

Focus is mainly material and social rather than spiritual.

5. Leadership Concept

Islamic System

Leader (Imām/Khalīfah) is a trustee (Amānah).

Accountable before Allah.

Leadership is a responsibility, not privilege.

Hadith:

“Each of you is a shepherd and each of you is responsible for his flock.” (Bukhari & Muslim)

Conventional System

Leader is political head elected or appointed.

Accountable mainly through legal or electoral processes.

No concept of divine accountability.

6. Law-Making Authority

Islamic System

Cannot legalize what Allah prohibited.

Example: Interest (Ribā) cannot be legalized even if majority approves.

Conventional System

Majority can legalize or prohibit anything.

Moral standards may change over time.

7. Moral Framework

Islamic System

Absolute moral values based on revelation.

Ethics are fixed and divine.

Conventional System

Moral values are relative.

Ethics may vary according to culture and public opinion.

8. Consultation vs Democracy

Islamic System

Shūrā (consultation) within limits of Sharī'ah.

Majority opinion is considered but cannot override divine law.

Conventional System

Democracy based on majority rule.

Majority decision is final authority.